

CONFLICT IN THE MIDDLE EAST

1945–1995

Key Topic 3: Attempts at a solution, 1974–95



David Ben-Gurion reads the Declaration of Independence beneath the portrait of Theodor Herzl (Tel Aviv, 14 May 1948).

OFFICIAL COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: "Why has peace proved so elusive in the Middle East?"

Contents

Lesson 1: KT 3.1: Diplomatic Negotiations: From Shuttle Diplomacy to Camp David, 1974–1979	Page 2
--	---------------

Lesson 2: KT 3.2: The Palestinian Issue: Lebanon, Sabra & Shatila, and the First Intifada, 1974–1993	Page 11
--	----------------

Lesson 3: KT 3.3: Attempts at a Solution: From the Oslo Accords to Oslo II, 1988–1995	Page 25
---	----------------

L1: KT 3.1: Diplomatic Negotiations: From Shuttle Diplomacy to Camp David, 1974–1979

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the significance of the oil crisis and the involvement of the USA and the USSR.
- ☐ Analyze Kissinger, 'shuttle diplomacy' and the reopening of the Suez Canal.
- ☐ Evaluate Sadat's visit to Israel (1977), Begin's visit to Egypt (1977), US President Carter and Camp David (1978) and the Treaty of Washington (1979).

In an unprecedented move that stunned the world, Egyptian President Anwar Sadat traveled to Jerusalem in 1977, offering peace. This bold step shattered the Arab taboo of refusing to talk to Israel and paved the way for the historic Camp David Accords, fundamentally altering the Middle East peace process.

Did you know?

- **Camp David Accords (1978):** Brokered by US President Jimmy Carter, leading to the first peace treaty between Israel and an Arab nation.
- **Sinai Return:** Israel agreed to return the entire Sinai Peninsula to Egypt in exchange for full diplomatic recognition.
- **Assassination:** Sadat was viewed as a traitor by many Arabs and was assassinated by Islamic extremists in 1981.

Source A : Begin, Carter, and Sadat at the Camp David Summit (September 1978)



Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin, US President Jimmy Carter, and Egyptian President Anwar Sadat standing together after 13 days of secret negotiations at Camp David, Maryland.

Q1. Why was US President Jimmy Carter's personal mediation indispensable in preventing the Camp David negotiations from collapsing?

Recall & Retrieval (Lesson 7: Yom Kippur War & Aftermath)

1. On what Jewish holy day did Egypt and Syria launch their surprise attack in October 1973?
2. What weapon technology did Egyptian forces use to breach the sand ramparts of the Bar-Lev Line in 1973?
3. What action taken by Arab oil-producing states (OPEC) during the 1973 war caused a global economic crisis?
4. Who was the US Secretary of State who pioneered 'shuttle diplomacy' between Middle Eastern capitals in 1974–75?
5. What was the massive sand fortification line built by Israel along the eastern bank of the Suez Canal after 1967?
6. Which Israeli general led the armoured counter-crossing of the Suez Canal into Egypt in mid-October 1973?
7. What United Nations resolution passed on 22 October 1973 brought about a ceasefire in the Yom Kippur War?
8. Who was Israel's Prime Minister during the Yom Kippur War who faced severe domestic criticism for intelligence failures?
9. Which superpower enacted a massive military airlift (Operation Nickel Grass) to resupply Israel with tanks and ammunition?
10. Who succeeded Gamal Abdel Nasser as President of Egypt in September 1970?

Vocabulary Check

Fill in the blanks using the vocabulary words below.

Stagflation | Shuttle Diplomacy | Sinai II Agreement | Likud | Camp David Accords | Treaty of Washington

In the years following the Yom Kippur War, Henry Kissinger utilized exhaustive _____ to mediate initial disengagements like the _____ between Israel and its neighbors. A major political shift occurred in Israel with the election of the right-wing _____ party, led by Menachem Begin. Despite Begin's hardline stance, intense negotiations with Egypt led to the historic _____ in 1978. This framework ultimately resulted in the 1979 _____, marking the first formal peace treaty between Israel and an Arab nation amidst an era of global economic _____ influenced by _____.

Source B : President Anwar Sadat Addresses the Israeli Knesset (November 1977)



Egyptian President Anwar Sadat, who made a historic and unprecedented visit to Israel in 1977 to pursue peace.

Operation Peace for Galilee (June 1982): Ariel Sharon's Invasion: The Yom Kippur War of October 1973 was a military conflict that triggered a global economic and geopolitical revolution. Alarmed by the massive US arms airlift to Israel (Operation Nickel Grass), the Arab members of OPEC (Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries) enacted the "Oil Weapon." They placed a total oil embargo on the United States, Denmark, and the Netherlands, while cutting production for other Western nations by 25%. This move had a devastating, cascading impact on the global economy. The price of crude oil quadrupled in a

matter of months, skyrocketing from \$3 to \$12 a barrel. Western industrial nations, highly dependent on cheap oil, plunged into a deep economic crisis characterized by soaring inflation (rising prices) and high unemployment. As oil prices rose, production costs increased, making goods more expensive; consequently, consumers bought fewer items, leading to factory bankruptcies and mass layoffs.

The Siege of Beirut & The Expulsion of the PLO to Tunisia:

cognitive_impact

The Sabra and Shatila Massacre (September 1982): For the superpowers, the crisis changed the calculation of Middle Eastern diplomacy. The Yom Kippur War had brought the United States and the Soviet Union to the brink of a nuclear confrontation. The United States, badly hit by the embargo, now had a powerful financial incentive to broker a lasting peace between Israel and its Arab neighbors to ensure the stable flow of Middle Eastern oil. Furthermore, US policymakers wanted to use diplomatic negotiations to pull Egypt out of the Soviet sphere of influence. Because Egypt and Syria refused to meet face-to-face with Israeli officials, US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger stepped in as a mediator. Kissinger pioneered a form of negotiation known as "shuttle diplomacy," flying back and forth between Cairo, Damascus, and Tel Aviv for two months to relay messages, draft proposals, and bridge the deep psychological divide between the hostile states.

Q2. How did the 1973 Yom Kippur War change the diplomatic calculations of the United States?

The Kahan Commission: Domestic Israeli Backlash & Sharon's Resignation:

shuttle_diplomacy

The Rise of Hezbollah: Shia Resistance in Southern Lebanon: Kissinger's efforts produced three highly important interim agreements. The Sinai I Agreement (January 1974) saw Israeli forces pull back from the west bank of the Suez Canal, creating a UN-patrolled buffer zone. The Golan Accord (May 1974) brokered a cease-fire line on the Golan Heights, with Israel withdrawing from Quneitra. The Sinai II Agreement (September 1975) saw Israel surrender the strategic Gidi and Mitla passes and the vital Abu Rudeis oil fields to Egypt. Crucially, the US established manned early-warning electronic monitoring stations in Sinai to guarantee compliance. A direct consequence of Kissinger's Sinai I agreement was the clearing of the Suez Canal. The canal had been blocked since the 1967 Six Day War by sunken ships and landmines. On 5 June 1975—exactly eight years to the day after its closure—President Anwar Sadat officially reopened the Suez Canal to international trade, providing a major boost to the Egyptian economy.

Q3. What was the result of Henry Kissinger's Sinai II Agreement (September 1975)?

Source C : The Camp David Accords (September 1978)



Begin, Carter, and Sadat shaking hands after successfully negotiating the Camp David Accords.

The Roots of Domestic Palestinian Frustration in Gaza and the West Bank: By 1977, the momentum of Kissinger's shuttle diplomacy had stalled. In May 1977, the right-wing Likud bloc came to power in Israel, with Menachem Begin installed as Prime Minister. Begin firmly believed in Israel's biblical claim to the entire Land of Israel, including the West Bank. Most observers assumed Begin's election would end all hopes of peace.

 sadat_faces

However, Anwar Sadat was facing severe internal pressures, a failing economy, and food riots in Cairo. Sadat realized only a dramatic, direct gesture could break the diplomatic deadlock. On 19 November 1977, Sadat's presidential plane landed at Ben Gurion Airport in Israel. The following day, he addressed the Israeli Knesset, offering Israel complete recognition and permanent peace in exchange for complete Israeli withdrawal from all occupied Arab lands. On 25 December 1977, Menachem Begin made a reciprocal visit to Ismailia, Egypt, for a summit with Sadat. However, this historic meeting failed to produce a breakthrough, and by mid-1978, direct talks between Egypt and Israel had once again broken down over Begin's refusal to dismantle Jewish settlements in the Sinai. To rescue the process, US President Jimmy Carter took a massive political risk, inviting both Sadat and Begin to the presidential retreat at Camp David, Maryland, for face-to-face negotiations.

Q4. What dramatic gesture did Anwar Sadat make on 19 November 1977 to break the diplomatic deadlock?

 camp_david

Source D : Map of the Sinai Peninsula: Camp David Settlement (1979)



Official cartographic map showing the 60,000 square kilometre Sinai Peninsula returned in phases by Israel to Egypt between 1979 and 1982 in exchange for diplomatic recognition and free passage through the Straits of Tiran.

Q5 Source Detective: Explain why control of Sharm ash Shaykh and the Strait of Tiran at the southern tip of Sinai was such a vital strategic issue in the peace treaty.

For 13 days, Carter acted as a tireless mediator. The grueling summit resulted in the signing of the Camp David Accords on 17 September 1978. Framework 1 addressed the wider Palestinian issue, agreeing to a five-year transitional period of autonomy for the West Bank and Gaza Strip. Framework 2 outlined a bilateral peace treaty: Israel agreed to a phased, complete withdrawal from the Sinai Peninsula, and Egypt agreed to normalise relations. On 26 March 1979, Begin, Sadat, and Carter signed the formal Treaty of Peace between Egypt and Israel (the Treaty of Washington). Israel returned the entire Sinai Peninsula to Egypt, which became demilitarised. In return, Egypt officially recognized Israel's right to exist, becoming the first Arab nation to do so. The Suez Canal and the Straits of Tiran were permanently open to Israeli maritime shipping.

Q6. Outline the key terms of Framework 2 of the 1978 Camp David Accords.

Source E : The Egypt-Israel Peace Treaty Signing (26 March 1979)



Israeli Prime Minister Menachem Begin, who signed the historic Egypt-Israel Peace Treaty in 1979.

 sinai_returned

While celebrated in the West, the peace treaty triggered a massive geopolitical backlash in the Middle East. The Arab League expelled Egypt for abandoning the Palestinian cause. Tragically, on 6 October 1981, Anwar Sadat was assassinated by radical Islamic militants within the Egyptian army who opposed

his peace with Israel. Begin also faced furious opposition from hardline settlers, but the Knesset approved the treaty with a massive majority of 84 votes to 19.

Q7. What was the tragic personal consequence for Anwar Sadat following the signing of the peace treaty?

Q8. Explain how the 1973 OPEC oil embargo pressured Western powers to pursue peace negotiations in the Middle East.



CONSOLIDATION & DISCUSSION

Recall & Analysis

Q9. Why did people hold contrasting views on President Anwar Sadat's decision to sign the 1979 peace treaty with Israel?

***Guidance:** Contrast the Egyptian perspective (regained the Sinai Peninsula without further casualties) against other Arab nations and Palestinians who felt Sadat signed a separate peace and abandoned the Palestinian cause.*



EXIT TICKET: SPOT THE HISTORICAL IMPOSTER

EXIT TICKET · TWO TRUTHS & ONE FALLACY

Identify the IMPOSTER among these three statements regarding the 1982 Lebanon War:

- Statement A: Israeli Defense Minister Ariel Sharon sent troops far beyond the declared 40-kilometer buffer zone to lay siege to Beirut and expel Yasser Arafat's PLO leadership to Tunisia.
- Statement B: The Sabra and Shatila massacres were carried out directly by Israeli soldiers following an explicit order from Prime Minister Menachem Begin.
- Statement C: The official Israeli Kahan Commission found Ariel Sharon bore "personal responsibility" for failing to prevent the massacre, forcing his resignation as Defense Minister.

***Teacher Guidance:** Task: Identify the false statement (Statement B: the massacre was committed by Christian Phalangist militiamen, though Israeli forces encircled the camps) and write the correction.*

L2: KT 3.2: The Palestinian Issue: Lebanon, Sabra & Shatila, and the First Intifada, 1974–1993

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand Arafat's speech to the UN (1974) and the significance of PLO activities in Lebanon.
- ☐ Analyze Israeli reprisals, the invasion of Lebanon (1982) and the results.
- ☐ Evaluate the situation in the Israeli occupied territories and the First Palestinian Intifada (1987–93).

While Egypt and Israel made peace, the Palestinians felt abandoned. Operating out of Lebanon, the PLO launched relentless attacks against Israel, leading to the devastating 1982 Israeli invasion of Lebanon. By 1987, Palestinian frustration inside the occupied territories exploded into a spontaneous, grassroots uprising known as the First Intifada.

Did you know?

- Lebanon War (1982): Israel invaded Lebanon to destroy the PLO, resulting in thousands of civilian casualties.
- Intifada (1987): Meaning 'shaking off', this was a massive Palestinian uprising in the West Bank and Gaza involving strikes and stone-throwing.
- Hamas: Formed during the Intifada, this militant Islamic group emerged as a rival to the secular PLO.

Source A : Ariel Sharon Overlooking Beirut During the Lebanon Invasion (June 1982)



Israeli Defence Minister Ariel Sharon reviewing maps and overlooking the besieged skyline of Beirut, Lebanon, during Operation Peace for Galilee in the summer of 1982.

Q1. Why did the Israeli invasion of Lebanon and the siege of Beirut provoke unprecedented domestic protests and international condemnation?

Recall & Retrieval (Lesson 8: Shuttle Diplomacy to Camp David)

1. Which Egyptian President stunned the world by flying to Jerusalem to address the Israeli Knesset in November 1977?
2. Who was the right-wing Likud Prime Minister of Israel who negotiated with Sadat?
3. What presidential retreat in Maryland hosted 13 days of intense secret negotiations brokered by Jimmy Carter in September 1978?
4. What was the formal peace treaty signed on the White House lawn between Egypt and Israel on 26 March 1979 called?
5. What major territory did Israel agree to return entirely to Egyptian sovereignty in exchange for peace and demilitarisation?
6. How did the Arab League punish Egypt for signing a separate bilateral peace treaty with Israel in 1979?
7. What tragic event occurred to President Anwar Sadat on 6 October 1981 during a military parade in Cairo?
8. Who succeeded Anwar Sadat as President of Egypt in October 1981?
9. What diplomatic method involved Henry Kissinger flying back and forth between Middle Eastern capitals to broker disengagement treaties?
10. What international maritime waterway did Egypt agree to open to Israeli commercial shipping under the 1979 treaty?

Vocabulary Check

Write a historically accurate sentence connecting two terms from the glossary box below.

UN Resolution 3236 | Fatahland | Operation Peace for Galilee | Sabra and Shatila | First Intifada | Hezbollah

Your Sentence:

Source B : The First Intifada (1987)



Palestinian youth confronting Israeli troops during the First Intifada, a spontaneous grassroots uprising.

The Spark in Jabalya (8 December 1987): The Uprising Erupts: Following the 1973 Yom Kippur War, the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) sought to capitalize on the shifting geopolitical landscape to advance its diplomatic standing. On 13 November 1974, PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat made a historic address to the United Nations General Assembly in New York. This invitation was highly significant, representing the first time a representative of a non-state national movement was permitted to address the UN General Assembly plenary. Arafat, who delivered his speech wearing his signature checkered keffiyeh and olive-green uniform, famously concluded his remarks with a powerful metaphorical warning: "I have come bearing an olive branch and a freedom fighter's gun. Do not let the olive branch fall from my hand."

The Dynamics of the Intifada: Stones Against Tanks:



The UNLU (Unified National Leadership of the Uprising): Grassroots Power: This dual-track message signaled that while the PLO was prepared to engage in international diplomacy to secure a sovereign Palestinian state, it would not abandon its armed struggle if diplomatic avenues were blocked. The diplomatic offensive yielded immediate results at the UN. Resolution 3236 formally recognized the inalienable rights of the Palestinian people to self-determination, and granted the PLO permanent Observer Status. At the Arab League Summit in Algiers, the PLO was officially recognized as the "sole legitimate representative of the Palestinian nation." Following its bloody expulsion from Jordan during the "Black September" civil war of 1970, the PLO relocated its central leadership, military apparatus, and thousands of fighters to Lebanon. Lebanon was an ideal haven: its central government in Beirut was weak, and the country already hosted over 400,000 Palestinian refugees living in camps.

Q2. What was the significance of UN Resolution 3236 (November 1974) for the PLO?

The Rise of Hamas (1987): Islamic Resistance Challenges the Secular PLO:



Yitzhak Rabin's "Iron Fist" & The Global Media War: By the mid-1970s, the PLO had established a powerful "state-within-a-state" in southern Lebanon, widely known as "Fatahland". The PLO operated its own checkpoints, collected taxes, ran hospitals, and established military training camps. From these bases, PLO guerrilla fighters launched cross-border raids and fired Katyusha rocket barrages into northern Israel, terrorizing the civilian settlements of the Galilee region. On 11 March 1978, a Fatah commando unit launched the Coastal Road Massacre, hijacking a civilian bus and engaging in a gun battle that resulted in the deaths of 37 Israeli civilians. In direct retaliation, Prime Minister Menachem Begin ordered the IDF to launch Operation Litani on 15 March 1978.

Q3. What was 'Fatahland' and how did it threaten Israeli security?

Arafat's Diplomatic Shift: Geneva (1988) & Recognition of Israel:



The Gulf War (1991): Arafat Backs Saddam Hussein & Loses Arab Aid: Over 26,000 IDF troops invaded southern Lebanon, occupying a 10-kilometer-wide security strip. The UN established the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL) to confirm the Israeli withdrawal. Israel withdrew but left control of the buffer zone to a friendly, pro-Israeli Christian militia known as the South Lebanon Army (SLA). The UNIFIL buffer failed to stop the conflict. The final trigger for full-scale war occurred on 3 June 1982, when the Abu Nidal Organization shot and critically wounded Shlomo Argov, Israel's ambassador to Great Britain. Although British intelligence confirmed the PLO was not responsible, Israeli Defense Minister Ariel Sharon used the assassination attempt as the necessary pretext to launch a long-planned, total invasion of Lebanon: Operation Peace for Galilee.

Q4. What pretext did Israeli Defense Minister Ariel Sharon use to launch Operation Peace for Galilee in June 1982?

Source C : Israeli Security Forces Response to the Intifada (1988)

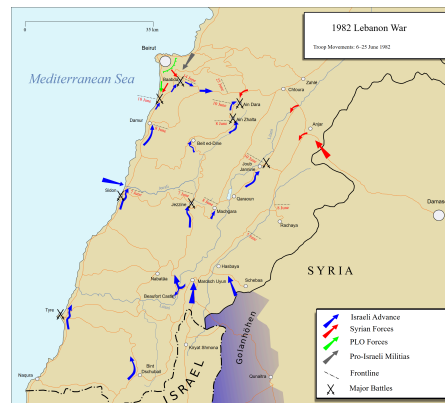


Israeli Prime Minister , who implemented a harsh 'Iron Fist' policy in response to the Intifada.

The Madrid Conference (1991): Setting the Stage for Direct Talks:

lebanese_invasion

Source D : Military Map: 1982 Lebanon War (Operation Peace for Galilee)



Military campaign map illustrating the June 1982 Israeli advances northward along the Mediterranean coast past Tyre and Sidon into Beirut, alongside clashes with Syrian forces in the Bekaa Valley.

Q5 Source Detective: Study the arrows marking the Israeli advance northward. How does the map demonstrate that Sharon pushed the invasion far beyond the initial 40-kilometre security zone to encircle Beirut?

On 6 June 1982, Israeli forces launched a massive armored invasion. Ariel Sharon secretly harbored much larger geopolitical ambitions: to completely destroy the PLO in Lebanon, defeat Syrian forces, and install a pro-Israeli Christian government in Beirut led by Maronite leader Bashir Gemayel. By mid-June, Israeli forces surrounded Lebanon's capital, trapping Yasser Arafat and 15,000 PLO fighters in West Beirut. For over two months, Israel subjected the city to relentless bombardments. To prevent total destruction, a multinational peacekeeping force supervised the evacuation of Yasser Arafat and over 14,000 fighters by ship to Tunis, Tunisia.

Q6. What were Ariel Sharon's larger geopolitical ambitions behind the 1982 invasion of Lebanon?

Having successfully expelled the PLO, Israel's close Maronite ally, Bashir Gemayel, was elected President of Lebanon. However, on 14 September 1982, Gemayel was assassinated in a massive bomb blast by Syrian agents.

In response to the assassination, the IDF occupied West Beirut. On 16 September 1982, Israeli forces surrounded the Palestinian refugee camps of Sabra and Shatila. Claiming PLO terrorists remained inside, Ariel Sharon authorized the Lebanese Christian Phalangist militias to enter the camps to clear them. Fueled by anger over the death of Gemayel, the Phalangists systematically slaughtered unarmed civilians. While the IDF held the perimeter and illuminated the night skies with flares, the militias murdered between 800 and 3,500 people. The revelation of the atrocities triggered immediate, furious international condemnation. The extraparliamentary peace movement "Peace Now" organized a protest of 400,000 Israelis in Tel Aviv. The Kahan Commission concluded that Defense Minister Ariel Sharon bore "personal, indirect responsibility" for the tragedy. He was forced to resign.

Q7. Describe the events and consequences of the Sabra and Shatila massacre in September 1982.

While the PLO leadership remained isolated in Tunis, the core of the Palestinian struggle shifted back to the occupied territories. On 8 December 1987, an Israeli military truck collided with a civilian car, killing four Palestinians. The local population erupted in massive demonstrations that swept across Gaza and the West Bank, marking the start of the First Palestinian Intifada ("The Shaking Off").

Q8. What event marked the start of the First Palestinian Intifada in December 1987?

Source E : PLO Evacuation from Beirut (August 1982)



Yasser Arafat, leader of the PLO, whose organization was forced into exile in Tunisia following the 1982 Lebanon War.

Unlike the PLO operations, the First Intifada was a grassroots, popular civilian uprising utilizing non-violent civil disobedience (strikes, boycotts) alongside low-level street violence. The iconic visual of the Intifada consisted of Palestinian youth throwing stones at heavily armored Israeli tanks. Israeli Defense Minister Yitzhak Rabin responded with a severe "Iron Fist" policy, ordering the IDF to "break the bones" of demonstrators. However, television cameras broadcasted graphic footage of heavily armed soldiers beating stone-throwing children across the globe. For the first time, global public sympathy shifted decisively toward the Palestinian cause, severely damaging Israel's international moral standing.

Q9. How did the First Intifada shift global public sympathy toward the Palestinian cause?

CONSEQUENCES OF THE FIRST INTIFADA

For the PLO	For Israel	The Rise of Hamas
Forced Yasser Arafat to renounce terrorism and officially accept the two-state solution (1988) to retain leadership.	Convinced Yitzhak Rabin and military planners that there was no purely military solution to the Palestinian issue.	Formed in 1987 as a rival to the PLO, Hamas rejected compromises and conducted violent armed attacks against Israelis.

Writing Historically: Level 9 Stylistic Masterclass

GCSE history examiners actively look for clear, sophisticated written expression that demonstrates analytical links between historical causes, events, and consequences.

- **1. Using Relative Clauses to Pack in Evidence (AO1):** Add vital historical information directly to a noun using relative pronouns like 'who', 'which', or 'whose'. For example: *Yasser Arafat, **who addressed the UN General Assembly in 1974 wearing his signature keffiyeh and military uniform, successfully secured international legitimacy...***
- **2. Using Noun Phrases in Apposition (AO1):** Place two noun phrases side-by-side to provide concise historical detail. For example: *Ariel Sharon, **the hardline Israeli Defense Minister, launched Operation Peace for Galilee in June 1982.***
- **3. Using Present Participles (AO2):** Link cause and effect using verbs ending in '-ing'. For example: *...Palestinian guerrillas launched frequent cross-border attacks, **provoking** disproportionate Israeli military reprisals.*

Q10. Explain the consequences of the 1982 Israeli siege of Beirut for the PLO leadership.

CONSOLIDATION & DISCUSSION

Recall & Analysis

Q11. Explain why international television broadcasts of the First Intifada damaged Israel's reputation across the world.

Guidance: Contrast television footage of heavily armed Israeli soldiers using tear gas and live ammunition against Palestinian teenagers and children armed only with stones.

EXIT TICKET: THE CAUSAL BALANCE SCALE

EXIT TICKET · THE CAUSAL BALANCE SCALE

Weigh the driving leadership of the First Intifada on a scale of 0 to 10:

- [0] 100% Spontaneous Grassroots Rebellion: Driven entirely by frustrated youth in Gaza and the West Bank throwing stones.
- [5] A Blend: Began spontaneously, but was quickly steered by local clandestine committees (UNLU).
- [10] 100% Orchestrated by Arafat: Controlled and ordered by the PLO leadership in exile from Tunisia.

Teacher Guidance: Task: Where on the scale do you place the uprising, and what is your single piece of historical evidence justifying why the PLO in Tunis was caught off guard?

L3: KT 3.3: Attempts at a Solution: From the Oslo Accords to Oslo II, 1988–1995

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- ☐ Understand the significance of Arafat's renunciation of terrorism in a speech at the UN (1988).
- ☐ Analyze changing superpower policies in the Middle East: US involvement in the Gulf War (1991), and the end of the Cold War.
- ☐ Evaluate Arafat, Rabin and the Oslo Accords (1993); the setting up of the Palestinian National Authority; the Israel-Jordan peace treaty (1994); and Oslo II (1995).

The sheer exhaustion of the Intifada forced both sides to the negotiating table in secret. In 1993, the world watched in awe as PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat and Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin shook hands on the White House lawn, signing the Oslo Accords. It seemed peace was finally possible, but extremists on both sides were determined to destroy it.

Did you know?

- Oslo Accords (1993): Created the Palestinian Authority with limited self-rule in parts of the West Bank and Gaza.
- Mutual Recognition: The PLO finally recognised Israel's right to exist, and Israel recognised the PLO as the representative of the Palestinians.
- Assassination of Rabin (1995): A right-wing Israeli extremist assassinated Yitzhak Rabin, severely derailing the peace process.

Source A : The Historic Oslo Handshake on the White House Lawn (13 September 1993)



Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin and PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat shaking hands on the White House lawn, encouraged by US President Bill Clinton, after signing the Oslo I Accord.

Q1. Why did the visual handshake between Rabin and Arafat symbolize an astonishing diplomatic breakthrough, and what major obstacles remained unresolved?

Recall & Retrieval (Lesson 9: Lebanon War & The First Intifada)

1. Which Israeli Defence Minister orchestrated the June 1982 invasion of Lebanon?
2. What was the official Israeli codename for the June 1982 invasion of Lebanon?
3. What notorious massacre of Palestinian civilians took place in Beirut in September 1982 by Christian Phalangist militias?
4. To which North African capital was Yasser Arafat and the PLO leadership evacuated in August 1982?
5. What Arabic term meaning 'shaking off' refers to the spontaneous grassroots Palestinian uprising that broke out in December 1987?
6. In which dense refugee camp in the Gaza Strip did the First Intifada begin following a fatal road collision?
7. What primary weapon used by Palestinian youths against Israeli soldiers captured global television headlines?
8. What Islamic resistance organisation was founded in December 1987 in Gaza as a militant rival to the secular PLO?
9. What historic concession did Yasser Arafat announce in a speech to the UN in Geneva in December 1988?
10. What official Israeli commission of inquiry found Ariel Sharon personally responsible for failing to prevent the Sabra and Shatila massacres?

Vocabulary Check

Write a clear definition and a historically accurate sentence for the term: **UNLU**

Source B : The Historic Oslo Handshake on the White House Lawn (13 September 1993)



Yitzhak Rabin, Yasser Arafat, and Bill Clinton sealing the Oslo I Accord on the White House lawn.

The Secret Negotiations in Norway: Circumventing the Hardliners: By late 1988, PLO Chairman Yasser Arafat realized that the political landscape was shifting beneath his feet. The First Palestinian Intifada had been launched and coordinated by grassroots local committees on the ground, bypassing the traditional PLO leadership isolated in Tunis. Arafat faced a major dilemma: his leadership was being rapidly overshadowed by new, highly popular underground leaders in the Unified National Leadership of the Uprising (UNLU) and radical Islamist groups like Hamas and Islamic Jihad.

Letters of Mutual Recognition: Breaking the Fifty-Year Taboo:

 arafat_1988

The Declaration of Principles (Oslo I, 1993): The White House Handshake: To regain political control, Arafat enacted a historic shift in PLO strategy. In November 1988, the Palestinian National Council officially accepted the principles of partition and a two-state solution—officially recognizing Israel's right to exist alongside a sovereign, independent Palestinian state in the occupied territories. In December 1988, on the strict insistence of the United States, Arafat delivered a historic speech to a special session

of the UN General Assembly in Geneva. In this speech, Arafat explicitly renounced and condemned all forms of terrorism. This met the long-standing US conditions for official diplomatic contact, forcing the Reagan administration to open formal diplomatic talks with the PLO.

Q2. How did Yasser Arafat enact a historic shift in PLO strategy in late 1988?

The Establishment of the Palestinian National Authority (PNA) in Gaza & Jericho: The international geopolitical order was completely transformed between 1989 and 1991. The dissolution of the Soviet Union (USSR) in December 1991 brought an end to the Cold War and fundamentally altered the balance of power in the Middle East.

The 1994 Israel-Jordan Peace Treaty: King Hussein Signs:



Oslo II (1995): Partitioning the West Bank into Areas A, B, and C: The collapse of the USSR was a devastating blow to the PLO, which lost its primary funding and diplomatic backing. Over 200,000 Soviet Jews migrated to Israel, leading to the expansion of Jewish settlements in the West Bank and displacing Palestinian workers. Arafat realized he had to secure a deal immediately. The end of the Cold War also meant the US emerged as the sole global superpower and used its leverage, threatening to withhold a \$10 billion loan guarantee, to force Israel's Prime Minister to negotiate. In August 1990, Iraqi dictator Saddam Hussein invaded Kuwait, triggering the 1991 Gulf War. Arafat made the disastrous decision to publicly support Saddam Hussein.

Q3. How did the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991 severely damage the PLO's geopolitical position?

Source C : The Israel-Jordan Peace Treaty (October 1994)



King Hussein of Jordan, who signed the historic peace treaty with Israel in 1994, normalizing relations between the two countries.

The Fatal Postponement: The Unresolved Final-Status Issues:



The Extremist Backlash: Hamas Suicide Bombings Sabotage the Process: Outraged by Arafat's betrayal, wealthy Gulf Arab states cut off all financial donations. Kuwait expelled over 300,000 Palestinian workers. The PLO was left bankrupt. To stabilize the region, the US and USSR co-sponsored the Madrid

Peace Conference in November 1991. While the public talks stalemated, they broke the taboo of direct negotiations. In June 1992, the moderate Labor Party came to power in Israel under Yitzhak Rabin. Rabin authorized secret, back-channel negotiations in Oslo, Norway.

Q4. Why was the PLO left bankrupt and diplomatically isolated following the 1991 Gulf War?

The Assassination of Yitzhak Rabin (4 November 1995): The Death of Peace:

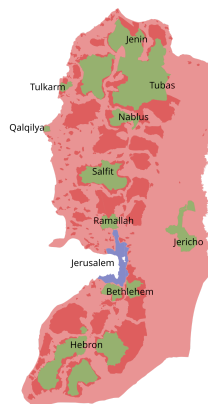


The urgency intensified in April 1993 when Hamas launched its first suicide car bombing. This convinced Rabin that Arafat's PLO was a moderate alternative. The secret negotiations produced the historic Oslo I Accords, signed on the White House lawn on 13 September 1993. Arafat renounced terrorism and recognized Israel, while Rabin recognized the PLO. An interim Palestinian National Authority (PNA) was established to govern Gaza and Jericho. In October 1994, Israel and Jordan signed a formal Treaty of Peace. King Hussein approached Rabin because Jordan was suffering economically after the Gulf War. US President promised to cancel Jordan's massive debts if it normalized relations.

Q5. What convinced Israeli Prime Minister Yitzhak Rabin to engage in secret negotiations with the PLO in 1993?



Source D : Map of the West Bank under Oslo II (1995)

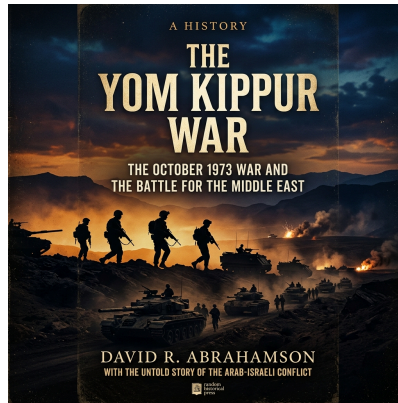


Map illustrating the territorial fragmentation of the West Bank: Area A (green, Palestinian cities with civil and security control), Area B (red, joint Israeli-Palestinian control), and Area C (pink, full Israeli civil and military control covering 60% of the land).

Q6 Source Detective: Study the distribution of Areas A, B, and C. Why did this fragmented "archipelago" of isolated Palestinian urban enclaves lead many Palestinians to view Oslo II as an unworkable compromise?

On 28 September 1995, Rabin and Arafat signed the Oslo II Accords, which detailed the expansion of Palestinian self-rule across the West Bank by dividing it into three zones.

Source E : Rally in Tel Aviv Before the Assassination of Yitzhak Rabin (November 1995)



The book cover of 'Yitzhak Rabin: Soldier, Leader, Statesman' depicting Rabin, who was assassinated by an Israeli extremist at a Tel Aviv peace rally.



oslo2

While Oslo II was celebrated, the division triggered a massive political backlash. Palestinians were frustrated that the PNA only controlled a fragmented archipelago (Area A), while Israel still controlled 70% of their land (Area C). Hamas launched suicide bus bombings. Right-wing Israelis were outraged by Rabin's concessions.

Q7. Why did the Oslo II Accords trigger a massive political backlash among Palestinians?



deadlock

On 4 November 1995, Yitzhak Rabin was assassinated at a peace rally in Tel Aviv by Yigal Amir, a radical right-wing Jewish law student. The assassination dealt a fatal blow to the peace process, leaving the "permanent status" issues completely unresolved.

Q8. What event dealt a fatal blow to the peace process on 4 November 1995?

Q9. Explain how Yasser Arafat's 1988 Geneva speech helped open the path towards the 1993 Oslo Accords.

The tragic assassination of Rabin highlighted the deep structural flaws of the Oslo Accords. While celebrated internationally as a breakthrough, the agreement was fundamentally ambiguous. It intentionally delayed the most difficult "permanent status" issues—such as the final borders, the status of Jerusalem, the right of return for Palestinian refugees, and the dismantling of Israeli settlements—to a later date. This delay created a dangerous vacuum of uncertainty. Right-wing Israelis viewed any land concessions as a threat to national security and biblical claims, while Palestinian hardliners argued that the PNA had essentially become a subcontractor for Israeli security, failing to deliver true sovereignty or halt settlement expansion. Ultimately, the Accords required a high level of mutual trust that simply did not exist on the ground.

Q10. Explain why the Oslo Accords deferred the most difficult 'permanent status' issues, and what problems this caused.



CONSOLIDATION & DISCUSSION

Recall & Analysis

Q11. Why did leaders who compromised for peace—such as Yitzhak Rabin and Anwar Sadat—face extreme danger from extremists on their own side?

Guidance: Both leaders were assassinated not by their foreign adversaries, but by religious and political extremists from their own people who viewed territorial concessions as treason.



EXIT TICKET: SPLIT-PERSPECTIVE FRONT PAGE

EXIT TICKET · SPLIT-PERSPECTIVE HEADLINES

Write two **6-word newspaper headlines** capturing the historic handshake between Yitzhak Rabin and Yasser Arafat on the White House lawn (13 September 1993):

- Headline A (Optimistic Global View - The New York Times): Celebrating historic mutual recognition and hope for peace.
- Headline B (Skeptical / Militant View - Hamas or Right-Wing Israeli Settler): Condemning the accords as a fatal betrayal.

Teacher Guidance: Strict constraint: Exactly 6 words per headline!